
Candidates answer **three** questions in total.

This unit is synoptic.

4.3 Unit Order

The normal order in which the unit assessments could be taken is AS Units F761 and F762 in the first year of study, leading to an AS GCE award; then A2 Units F763 and F764 leading to the Advanced GCE award. However, the unit assessments may be taken in any order.

Alternatively, candidates may take a valid combination of unit assessments at the end of their AS GCE or Advanced GCE course in a 'linear' fashion.

4.4 Unit Options (at AS/A2)

There are no optional units in the AS GCE specification; for AS GCE Geography candidates must take AS Units F761 and F762.

There are no optional units in the Advanced GCE specification; for Advanced GCE Geography candidates take AS Units F761 and F762, *and* A2 Units F763 and F764.

4.5 Synoptic Assessment (A Level GCE)

Synoptic assessment is included in both the A2 units. The definition of synoptic assessment in the context of geography is as follows.

Synoptic assessment involves assessment of candidates' ability to draw on their understanding of the connections between different aspects of the subject represented in the specification and to demonstrate their ability to 'think like a geographer'.

Synoptic assessment will require candidates to go beyond the knowledge, understanding and skills outlined in the unit content to draw upon those in previously studied units. Tasks may present candidates with questions in an unfamiliar setting or draw on material that connects various units.

Examples of synoptic assessment tasks that may be set include:

- decision-making / problem-solving / issue-evaluating exercises requiring candidates to draw together relevant knowledge, understanding and skills of the specification, to tackle a decision, problem or issue that is new to them;

- an essay question exploring key geographical concepts through linkages between physical, human and environmental geography;
- an assessment on a particular region or area, which is on a scale that allows candidates to draw together and apply relevant knowledge, understanding and skills of processes or concepts of the specification;
- the use of research and investigation skills in Unit F764 based on examples drawn from work carried out at AS and in A2 Unit F763.

4.6 Assessment Availability

There are **two** examination series each year, in January and June.

In 2009, only AS units will be assessed.

From 2010, both AS units and A2 units will be assessed.

4.7 Assessment Objectives

There are three assessment objectives, AO1, AO2 and AO3.

Candidates are expected to demonstrate the following (in the context of the content des

- **AO1 Demonstrate knowledge and understanding** of the content, concepts and p
- **AO2 Analyse, interpret and evaluate** geographical information, issues and view p
apply understanding in unfamiliar contexts;
- **AO3 Investigate, conclude and communicate:** select and use a variety of metho
and techniques (including the use of new technologies) to investigate questions and
reach conclusions and communicate findings.

AO weightings in AS GCE

Unit	% of AS GCE		
	AO1	AO2	AO3
AS Unit F761: <i>Managing Physical Environments</i>	25	10	15
AS Unit F762: <i>Managing Change in Human Environments</i>	25	10	15
	50	20	30

AO weightings in Advanced GCE

Unit	% of Advanced GCE		
	AO1	AO2	AO3
AS Unit F761: <i>Managing Physical Environments</i>	12.5	5	7.5
AS Unit F762: <i>Managing Change in Human</i>			

40

30

30

100

4.8 Quality of Written Communication

Quality of written communication is met through all AOs and is assessed in all units. Credit may be restricted if communication is unclear.

Candidates should:

- ensure that text is legible and that spelling, punctuation and grammar are accurate so that meaning is clear;
- select and use a form and style of writing appropriate to its purpose and the complex subject matter;
- organise information clearly and coherently, using specialist vocabulary when appropriate.

This specification provides opportunities to assess the quality of written communication by:

- the use of extended writing tasks in all assessment units;
- expecting candidates to use specialist subject vocabulary throughout;
- the use of a variety of question types and wordings to encourage a variety of forms and styles of response.

5.1 Making Unit Entries

Please note that centres must be registered with OCR in order to make any entries, including estimated entries. It is recommended that centres apply to OCR to become a registered centre well in advance of making their first entries. Centres must have made an entry for a unit in order for OCR to supply the appropriate forms.

It is essential that unit entry codes (the four-figure alpha-numeric codes given in brackets at the end of the unit title) are quoted in all correspondence with OCR. See Sections 4.1 and 4.2 for these unit entry codes.

5.2 Making Qualification Entries

Candidates must enter for qualification certification separately from unit assessment(s). If a certification entry is **not** made, no overall grade can be awarded.

Candidates may enter for:

- AS GCE certification (entry code H083).
- Advanced GCE certification (entry code H483).

A candidate who has completed all the units required for the qualification may enter for certification either in the same examination series (within a specified period after publication of results) or in a later series.

AS GCE certification is available from June 2009.
Advanced GCE certification is available from June 2010.

5.3 Grading

All GCE units are awarded a-e. The Advanced Subsidiary GCE is awarded on the scale A-E. The Advanced GCE is awarded on the scale A-E with access to an A*. To be awarded an A*, candidates will need to achieve a grade A on their full A Level qualification and an A* on the aggregate of their A2 units. Grades are reported on certificates. Results for candidates who fail to achieve the minimum grade (E or e) will be recorded as *unclassified* (U or u) and this is **not** certificated.

(UMS) enables comparison of candidates' performance across units. A two-unit AS GCE has a total of 200 *uniform* marks and the four-unit AS GCE has 400 *uniform* marks.

A candidate's raw mark for each unit is converted to a *uniform* mark. The maximum *uniform* mark depends on that unit's weighting in the specification. In these Geography AS and A2 units of the Advanced GCE specification have UMS weightings of 100 and 120 respectively and the **two** units of the AS GCE specification have UMS weightings of 100 and 120 respectively. The *uniform* mark totals are 100/100/120/80 respectively. Each unit's raw mark is converted to a *uniform* mark so that the *uniform* mark boundary at the same grade. Intermediate marks are used on a *uniform* mark basis.

The following table corresponds to *unit* grades as follows.

Maximum Unit Uniform Mark	Unit Grade				
	a	b	c	d	e
120	120–96	95–84	83–72	71–60	59–48
100	100–80	79–70	69–60	59–50	49–40
80	80–64	63–56	55–48	47–40	39–32

The centre converts the unit *uniform* marks and compares these to pre-set boundaries (shown in the table) to determine the *qualification* grade.

Qualification Grade				
A	B	C	D	E
200–160	159–140	139–120	119–100	99–80
400–320	319–280	279–240	239–200	199–160

A candidate who achieves at least 320 *uniform* marks in their Advanced GCE, ie grade A, and at least 160 *uniform* marks in their two A2 units will receive an A* grade.

Enquiries and Appeals

In certain circumstances, a centre may wish to query the grade available to one or more candidates. It is possible to make an appeal against an outcome of such an enquiry. Enquiries about results should be made immediately following the series in which the relevant unit was taken.

In response to enquiries on results and appeals, centres should consult the Joint Council for the Advancement and Support of Education and the document *Enquiries about Results and Appeals: Information for Centres* produced by the Joint Council. Copies of the most recent editions are available from OCR.

5.5 Shelf-life of Units

Individual unit results, prior to certification of the qualification, have a shelf-life limited only by that of the qualification.

5.6 Unit and Qualification Re-sits

There is no restriction on the number of times a candidate may re-sit each unit before entering for certification for an AS GCE or Advanced GCE.

Candidates may enter for the full qualifications an unlimited number of times.

5.7 Guided Learning Hours

AS GCE Geography requires **180** guided learning hours in total.

Advanced GCE Geography requires **360** guided learning hours in total.

5.8 Code of Practice/Subject Criteria/Common Criteria Requirements

These specifications comply in all respects with the current *GCSE, GCE, GNVQ and AEA Code of Practice*, as available on the QCA website; the subject criteria for GCE Geography; and *The Statutory Regulation of External Qualifications 2004*.

5.9 Arrangements for Candidates with Particular Requirements

For candidates who are unable to complete the full assessment or whose performance may be adversely affected through no fault of their own, teachers should consult *Access Arrangements and Special Consideration Regulations and Guidance Relating to Candidates who are Eligible for Adjustments in Examinations*. In such cases, advice should be sought from OCR as early as possible during the course.

5.10 Prohibited Qualifications and Classification Code

Candidates who enter for the OCR GCE specifications may not also enter for any other GCE specification with the certification title *Geography* in the same examination series.

Every specification is assigned to a national classification code indicating the subject area to which it belongs.

Centres should be aware that candidates who enter for more than one GCE qualification with the same classification code will have only one grade (the highest) counted for the purpose of the School and College Achievement and Attainment Tables.

The classification code for these specifications is 3910.

6.1 Overlap with other Qualifications

Geography by its very nature and its locational approach overlaps with many other subjects, but more specifically with the following.

Overlap with other qualifications

	Unit F761	Unit F762	Unit F763	Unit F764
GCE Biology			✓	✓
GCE Business Studies		✓	✓	✓
GCE Economics		✓	✓	
GCE Geology	✓		✓	
GCE Science	✓	✓	✓	
GCE Sociology			✓	✓
GCE Travel and Tourism		✓	✓	✓

6.2 Progression from these Qualifications

Throughout the course of study candidates are encouraged to develop a critical understanding of how the physical environment interacts with human activities to produce distinctive dynamic spatial patterns at a range of scales from very local to global.

The specifications therefore provide a suitable foundation for the study of geography or related courses in higher education. Equally they are suitable for candidates intending to pursue geography-based careers or careers in business, various social sciences and sciences, or as part of a course of general education.

6.3 Key Skills Mapping

These specifications provide opportunities for the development of the Key Skills of *Communication*, *Application of Number*, *Information Technology*, *Working with Others*, *Improving Own Learning and Performance* and *Problem Solving* at Levels 2 and/or 3. However, the extent to which this evidence fulfils the Key Skills criteria at these levels will be totally dependent on the style of teaching and learning adopted for each unit.

Following table indicates where opportunities *may* exist for at least some coverage of Key Skills criteria at Levels 2 and/or 3 for each unit.

C				AoN			IT			WwO			IOLP		
.1a	.1b	.2	.3	.1	.2	.3	.1	.2	.3	.1	.2	.3	.1	.2	.3
✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓					✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓					✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓				✓	✓
✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Spiritual, Moral, Ethical, Social, Legislative, Economic and Cultural Issues

The following specifications offer opportunities which can contribute to an understanding of the following topics.

Unit F761 *Managing Physical Environments*, opportunities lie in the coverage of

conflicts in the use of drainage basins;

the impact of, and the management of, flooding;

planning and management of coastal environments;

conflicts resulting from coastal management;

how human factors make environments ecologically vulnerable;

conflicts with indigenous populations when environments are developed;

ways that ensure sustainable development in fragile environments.

Unit F762 *Managing Change in Human Environments* opportunities lie in the coverage of

factors influencing land-use patterns;

social deprivation – its characteristics and causes;

problems of managing the growth in demand for public services;

management strategies used to help areas become increasingly sustainable;

- factors influencing the pattern of energy supply;
- opportunities and problems created by energy exploitation;
- renewable energy sources;
- opportunities and problems created by the development of tourism;
- the development of sustainable tourism.

In A2 Unit F763: *Global Issues*, opportunities lie in the coverage of:

- the impact of, and reaction to, natural hazards;
- the effectiveness of managing natural hazards;
- human impact on the climate;
- human influences on ecosystems;
- conservation and environmental management;
- population growth and overpopulation;
- resource development and the factors influencing their development;
- the development continuum;
- development of sustainable resources;
- globalisation and its impacts;
- the development gap;
- the role of transnational corporations;
- international trade and aid;
- levels of development and quality of life;
- impact of economic inequalities on social and environmental issues;
- variations in the type and level of pollution;
- approaches to reducing inequalities including legal, economic and social.

A2 Unit F764: *Geographical Skills* is a skills unit requiring research and candidates may select topics that explore one or more of these issues.

6.5 Sustainable Development, Health and Safety Considerations and European Developments

These specifications support these issues, consistent with current EU agreements.

Sustainable development is a theme that underpins all units with the exception of A2 Unit F764: *Geographical Skills*.

Health and Safety is an important issue in A2 Unit F764: *Geographical Skills*.

European developments can exemplify various aspects of all units with the exception of A2 Unit F764: *Geographical Skills*, specifically in AS Unit F762: *Managing Change in Human Environments* and A2 Unit F763: *Global Issues*.

6.6 Avoidance of Bias

OCR has taken great care in the preparation of these specifications and assessment materials to avoid bias of any kind.

6.7 Language

These specifications and associated assessment materials are in English only.

6.8 Disability Discrimination Act Information Relating to these Specifications

AS/A Levels often require assessment of a broad range of competences. This is because they are general qualifications and, as such, prepare candidates for a wide range of occupations and higher level courses.

The revised AS/A Level qualification and subject criteria were reviewed to identify whether any of the competences required by the subject presented a potential barrier to any disabled candidates. If this was the case, the situation was reviewed again to ensure that such competences were included only where essential to the subject. The findings of this process were discussed with disability groups and with disabled people.

Reasonable adjustments are made for disabled candidates in order to enable them to access the assessments. For this reason, very few candidates will have a complete barrier to any part of the assessment. Information on reasonable adjustments is found in *Access Arrangements and Special Consideration: Regulations and Guidance Relating to Candidates who are Eligible for Adjustments in Examinations* produced by the Joint Council (refer to Section 5.9 of this specification).

Candidates who are still unable to access a significant part of the assessment, even after exploring all possibilities through reasonable adjustments, may still be able to receive an award. They would be given a grade on the parts of the assessment they have taken and there would be an indication on their certificate that not all of the competences have been addressed. This will be kept under review and may be amended in the future.

Requirements for fieldwork are sufficiently flexible for all candidates to participate.

Candidates with visual impairments may have difficulty in demonstrating skills related to analysis, interpretation and evaluation of geographical information including maps, 3-D and colour images.

Performance descriptions have been created for all GCE subjects. They describe the learning outcomes and levels of attainment likely to be demonstrated by a representative candidate performing at the A/B and E/U boundaries for AS and A2.

In practice most candidates will show uneven profiles across the attainments listed, with strengths in some areas compensating in the award process for weaknesses or omissions elsewhere. Performance descriptions illustrate expectations at the A/B and E/U boundaries of the AS and A2 as a whole; they have not been written at unit level.

Grade A/B and E/U boundaries should be set using professional judgement. The judgement should reflect the quality of candidates' work, informed by the available technical and statistical evidence. Performance descriptions are designed to assist examiners in exercising their professional judgement. They should be interpreted and applied in the context of individual specifications and their associated units. However, performance descriptions are not designed to define the content of specifications and units.

The requirement for all AS and A level specifications to assess candidates' quality of written communication will be met through one or more of the assessment objectives.

The performance descriptions have been produced by the regulatory authorities in collaboration with the awarding bodies.

Performance descriptions for geography

Assessment objective 1	Assessment objective 2	Assessment objective 3
Demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the content, concepts and processes.	Analyse, interpret and evaluate geographical information, issues and viewpoints and apply understanding in unfamiliar contexts.	Select and use a variety of methods, skills and techniques (including the use of new technologies) to investigate questions and issues, reach conclusions and communicate findings.
Candidates characteristically: a) demonstrate detailed knowledge and understanding of a range of concepts and processes b) demonstrate detailed knowledge and understanding of subject-specific material.	Candidates characteristically: a) analyse and interpret geographical information, issues and viewpoints b) offer a valid evaluation of geographical information, issues and viewpoints c) demonstrate the ability to apply geographical understanding to unfamiliar contexts at different scales.	Candidates characteristically: a) select and use appropriately a range of methods, skills and techniques (including new technologies) when investigating questions and issues b) reach valid conclusions and communicate findings clearly in a structured manner appropriate to the task.
Candidates characteristically: a) demonstrate some knowledge and understanding of some concepts and processes b) show basic knowledge and understanding of subject-specific material.	Candidates characteristically: a) offer limited and inconsistent analysis and interpretation of geographical information, issues and viewpoints b) attempt some limited evaluation of geographical information, issues and viewpoints c) show some limited ability to apply aspects of geographical understanding to unfamiliar contexts.	Candidates characteristically: a) use a limited range of methods, skills and techniques (which may include new technologies) to attempt to investigate questions and issues b) draw some limited conclusions c) communicate findings which broadly address the tasks.

mance descriptions for geography

Assessment objective 1	Assessment objective 2	Assessment objective 3
Demonstrate knowledge and understanding of the content, concepts and processes.	Analyse, interpret and evaluate geographical information, issues and viewpoints and apply understanding in unfamiliar contexts.	Select and use a variety of methods, skills and techniques (including the use of new technologies) to investigate questions and issues, reach conclusions and communicate findings.
Candidates characteristically: a) demonstrate knowledge and understanding of a wide range of concepts and processes b) show thorough knowledge and understanding of subject-specific material.	Candidates characteristically: a) accurately and competently analyse and interpret geographical information, issues and viewpoints b) offer a thorough evaluation of geographical information, issues and viewpoints in relation to specific geographical concepts c) demonstrate the ability to apply accurate and appropriate geographical understanding to unfamiliar contexts with precision at a range of scales.	Candidates characteristically: a) select and use appropriately and accurately a wide range of methods, skills and techniques (including new technologies) when thoroughly investigating questions and issues b) reach substantiated and valid conclusions c) communicate findings accurately and appropriately to the task.
Candidates characteristically: a) demonstrate some knowledge and understanding of the main concepts and processes b) show some understanding of subject-specific material.	Candidates characteristically: a) show some attempts to analyse and interpret geographical information, issues and viewpoints with varying degrees of success b) offer some evaluation of geographical information, issues and viewpoints with variable success c) show some ability to apply geographical understanding to unfamiliar contexts with some degree of accuracy.	Candidates characteristically: a) use a range of methods, skills and techniques (which include new technologies) to investigate questions and issues with varying degrees of success. b) draw some straightforward conclusions c) communicate findings broadly appropriate to the task.